

COGS OF INDIA *Ali's archive has 100,000-plus negatives that have been restored over seven years*

devoted to Ali's four-decade engagement with industry and labour.

Ali began his career at 17 as an assistant at the celebrated Calcutta studio Bourne & Shepherd. In 1948, he established his own commercial practice, Universal Camera Arts, in central Calcutta, when the city was a major centre of commerce, engineering and manufacturing.

Ali's photographs unfold against the backdrop of Jawaharlal Nehru's vision of a newly independent India. The Five-Year Plans placed steel mills, dams and power stations at the centre of a state-led programme of economic development. Devika Daulet-Singh, director at PHOTOINK, encountered Ali's work in Delhi in 2016. Three years later, his daughter, Nafisa Ali, entrusted the archive to PHOTOINK for restoration. "We discovered just how prolific Ali's work is," says Daulet-Singh. "He photographed practically every industry being set up in post-Independence India."

Ali's archive contains more than 100,000 negatives and has been undergoing restoration for seven years. It focuses on industrial landscapes, workers' portraits and rare photographs of women at work.

There is a striking attentiveness to Ali's subjects. Colliers appear in the subterranean world of the mines, while laboratory technicians are captured in moments of intense precision. His compositions isolate workers within their environments. His photographs give these workers a visible place in the story of India's industrial transformation. ■

—Nikhil Sardana

The show is on till Oct. 24



ART ▶

A CELEBRATION OF **LOVE**

KNMA's annual festival **celebrates India's rich dance traditions** over four days of performances at Sunder Nursery in Delhi

Following editions dedicated to theatre and music, the Kiran Nadar Museum of Art's annual festival turns this year to India's dance traditions. Curated by Leela Samson, the festival brings together 14 performances, including six special commissions, featuring veteran and emerging artists.

"Dance, music and poetry, in every language and dialect of India, have for centuries been consumed by the idea of love. Love in all its dimensions is our theme for this festival. Stories and songs that capture that love, prayers to the divine as the soul searches for the truth of life, and tales of unrequited love," said Samson.

"DANCE, MUSIC AND POETRY IN INDIA HAVE BEEN **CONSUMED BY THE IDEA OF LOVE FOR CENTURIES**," SAYS CURATOR LEELA SAMSON, UNDERLINING THIS YEAR'S THEME

The festival opens with Chenda Melam, a traditional percussion ensemble from Kerala, and concludes with Basanta Anurāga, which celebrates Krishna through spring, love and longing. Highlights include Śubhārambha, an excerpt from the Manipuri Sankirtana tradition; Śṛṅgāramanjarī, inspired by the timeless story of Nala and Damayanti; and Milan, a choreographic interpretation of the life and poetry of Punjabi mystic Piro.

"This edition of the KNMA festival extends the ideas of vulnerability in art, overlapping cultures and continuums.... The selection cuts across divides, to surrender to divinity in whatever form a soul chooses," says Samson. ■

—Neha Kirpal

The show is on from Oct. 15–18